

I AM HE

*The Absolute Formula — How the God of Israel Reveals Himself in
Jesus the Messiah*

“See now that I, even I, am he. There is no god with me.”

Deuteronomy 32:39 (WEB)

“Unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins.”

John 8:24 (WEB)

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A Note on the Scriptures

Every verse in this book is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a modern, public-domain translation. We chose it on purpose. It can be read, copied, printed, shared, and translated by anyone, anywhere, without permission or payment — a free Bible for a free gospel. It also has a quiet advantage for our subject: where many translations smooth the Hebrew into "I am he" or "I am the one," the WEB consistently preserves the wording "**I am he,**" and it renders the personal name of God as "**Yahweh.**" That makes the thread we are tracing easier to see with the naked eye.

Where it matters, we will go underneath the English to the **Hebrew**, the **Greek** of the Septuagint and the New Testament, and the **Latin** of the Vulgate — not to show off the languages, but because the whole argument lives in the words themselves. You do not need to read Hebrew, Greek, or Latin to follow this book. Everything is transliterated and explained. But you should know that the case does not depend on a clever English translation. It is there in the oldest words we have.

A Note to Every Reader

This is not a book written to win an argument and leave you standing in the rubble. It is written to put one question in front of you so plainly that you cannot un-see it, and then to let you decide what to do with it.

If you are a **Christian**, this book is discipleship: it will show you that the deity of Jesus is not a doctrine bolted onto the Bible from the outside but a thread running through the whole of it, and it will give you something solid to stand on and to share.

If you are an **atheist or a skeptic**, you are welcome here. We will not ask you to start by believing anything. We will ask only that you read the texts honestly and follow the words where they lead.

If you are **Jewish**, you hold the older and the larger part of this story — the Torah, the Prophets, the Writings, the Shema, the holy name. This book takes your Scriptures with the deepest seriousness, because it is *from* your Scriptures that the formula comes. We will disagree, but we will not caricature, and we will not demean.

If you are a **Muslim**, you already confess that God is one and that idolatry is the great sin. So do we. This book is, in part, a careful answer to the honest question, "Where did Jesus ever claim to be God?" — and the answer is more interesting than either side usually admits.

If you are a **Jehovah's Witness**, you love the name of God and the kingdom of God, and you read your Bible. So let us read it together, in the Hebrew and the Greek, and see what the words actually say.

We compare beliefs in this book. We never demean persons. The God who says "I am he" is the God who is "near to those who have a broken heart" (Psalm 34:18). If you read all the way to the end and walk away unconvinced, you will at least walk away knowing exactly what we believe and why — and you will have been treated as a friend.

One question holds the whole book together. We will ask it on the first page and the last, and on most of the pages between:

Who is the "He"?

Chapter One — The Forgotten Word

The word everyone walks past

Almost everyone who argues about the divinity of Jesus argues about two words: *I am*. The believer says, "Jesus said 'I am,' so He was claiming to be God." The skeptic answers, "People say 'I am' all the time — 'I am hungry,' 'I am tired,' 'I am the one you're looking for.' That proves nothing." And the conversation dies there, both sides convinced the other is being naive.

They are arguing about the wrong word.

The phrase that matters in the Hebrew Scriptures is not simply "I am." It is **"I am he."** And the forgotten word — the word that carries the whole weight — is the little one at the end:

He.

In Hebrew the formula is two words:

אני הוא *ʾānî hû* *literally, "I — He."*

Biblical Hebrew often leaves out the verb "to be," because it is understood. So *ʾānî hû* — "I, He" — is naturally and correctly translated **"I am he."** It is not a sentence fragment or a stray bit of grammar. In a specific set of passages, it is a title. It is the way the God of Israel, and no one else, says who He is.

When the Hebrew Scriptures were translated into Greek a couple of centuries before Jesus — the translation we call the **Septuagint** (LXX), the Bible most of the early church actually read — the translators rendered *ʾānî hû* with two Greek words:

ἐγώ ειμι *egō eimi* *"I am."*

And the Latin Vulgate, the Bible of the Western church for a thousand years, rendered it:

ego sum — *"I am," and in some places ego ipse sum — "I myself am he."*

Hold those three together, because the rest of the book hangs on them:

Language	Formula	Transliteration	Sense
Hebrew	אני הוא	<i>ʾānî hû</i>	"I am he"
Greek (LXX)	ἐγώ ειμι	<i>egō eimi</i>	"I am [he]"

Language	Formula	Transliteration	Sense
Latin (Vulgate)	ego sum / ego ipse	<i>ego sum</i>	"I am [he] / I myself"

Now notice what happens. The Greek phrase *egō eimi* — "I am" — is exactly the phrase that lands, again and again, on the lips of Jesus in the Gospel of John. The very words the Septuagint used to translate God's self-identification in Isaiah are the words Jesus uses about Himself. And in the most famous of them, He uses them in a context so charged that His hearers pick up stones.

So the question is not, "Did Jesus say the ordinary words 'I am'?" Of course He did, and so does everyone. The question is sharper and far more dangerous:

Was Jesus speaking the formula? And if He was — who is the "He" that He claimed to be?

Why "He" and not just "I am"

Let us be honest about something right away, because honesty is the only thing that will make this book worth your time. If the entire argument were, "Jesus said *egō eimi*, and *egō eimi* means 'I am,' and 'I AM' is God's name, therefore Jesus is God," the argument would be weak. It would be too easy to break. In the very same Gospel of John, a man born blind, after he is healed, is asked whether he is really the beggar people knew — and he answers, *egō eimi*, "I am" (John 9:9). He is not claiming to be God. He is saying, "Yes, that's me."

Grammar alone proves nothing. A phrase is not a magic spell. This is the first thing a thoughtful skeptic will say, and the skeptic is right.

So the case in this book is not built on grammar alone. It is built on a **pattern** — a specific, repeated, unmistakable pattern of divine self-identification that begins in the Torah, swells through Isaiah into a kind of refrain, and then reappears, deliberately and in matching contexts, on the lips of Jesus. The argument is cumulative. It is the difference between hearing someone hum three random notes and hearing them hum the first three notes of a national anthem in a stadium. The notes are ordinary. The pattern is not.

That pattern always centers on the forgotten word: **He**.

Not merely, "I exist."

Not merely, "I was here before Abraham."

Not merely, "I am the Messiah you've been waiting for."

But: **I am He.** I am *the* One. I am the only One. There is no other beside Me.

The shape of the journey

Here is where we are going, so you can see the whole staircase before we climb it.

In **Chapter Two**, we will watch the formula be born, in the Song of Moses: "*See now that I, even I, am he*" (Deuteronomy 32:39). We will see that from its very first appearance, "I am he" means one specific thing: *there is no god beside me*.

In **Chapter Three**, we will walk into the courtroom of Isaiah, where Yahweh puts the idols of the nations on trial and identifies Himself, over and over, with the same two words — the First and the Last, the only Savior, the One who blots out sins, the One who tells the future before it happens, so that His people will "*know and believe... and understand that I am he.*"

In **Chapter Four**, we will hear the formula again — in the mouth of a Galilean carpenter, in the same words the Greek Bible used for Yahweh, in contexts that echo Isaiah point for point, until the night He is arrested and a cohort of soldiers falls to the ground at the sound of it.

In **Chapter Five**, we will widen the lens and find that the rest of the New Testament does the same thing in a hundred other ways: the Word who was God and was with God; the glory Isaiah saw, which John says was *His* glory; the knee that bows and the tongue that confesses; the First and the Last who died and is alive forever.

In **Chapter Six**, we will stop and face every serious objection without flinching — from the skeptic, the Jewish reader, the Muslim reader, the Jehovah's Witness, and the careful historian. We will not strawman a single one. Some of them are very good objections, and they deserve real answers.

In **Chapter Seven**, we will come back to the question we started with, and we will answer it. And then the book will turn from argument to invitation — because the One who says "I am he" did not reveal Himself so that we could win debates, but so that we would not, in His own sobering words, "die in your sins."

Take your time. Keep a Bible open if you have one. And keep your eye on the small word that carries the weight of the world.

He.

So from its birth, "I am he" is not a phrase about mere existence. It is a phrase about **unrivaled, exclusive, divine identity**. To say "I am He" is to say, "I am the One who alone is God, who alone holds life and death, from whom no power in heaven or earth can rescue anyone."

Tuck that away. It will matter enormously when we hear the same phrase, in the same form, said by Someone standing in a temple courtyard in Jerusalem.

The Shema: the rock under everything

To understand why "I am he" is such a thunderclap, you have to stand where Israel stands. The center of Israel's faith — the verse a faithful Jew recites morning and evening, the words Jesus Himself called the first of all the commandments (Mark 12:29) — is the **Shema**:

"Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one." — Deuteronomy 6:4 (WEB)

This is the most important sentence in the Hebrew Bible. There is one God. His name is Yahweh. He alone is to be loved with all the heart and soul and strength. Everything else in Israel's law, history, and hope rests on this one rock.

Now — and this is crucial for every reader, especially our Jewish and Muslim friends — **nothing in this book asks you to give up the Shema**. This is not a book that smuggles a second god in through the back door. The argument of the New Testament, as we will see, is not "there are two Gods" or "there are three Gods." The argument is that the *one* God of the Shema, the one Yahweh, has made Himself known in a way Israel did not fully expect — and that the One who says "I am he" in Isaiah is the same One who says "I am he" in John.

If that claim is false, it is blasphemy, and you should reject it with all your strength. If it is true, it is the most important thing in the world, and no amount of discomfort should keep you from it. There is no third option where it is merely "a nice idea." We will let the texts decide.

"God is not a man"

Right here at the foundation, an honest objection arises, and we will meet it now rather than dodge it. Israel's Scriptures insist that God is not a creature:

"God is not a man, that he should lie, nor a son of man, that he should repent." — Numbers 23:19 (WEB)

"For I am God, and not man — the Holy One among you." — Hosea 11:9 (WEB)

Does this not slam the door on any claim that a man could be God?

It would — if the Christian claim were that God *stopped being God and became merely a man*, or that a mere man was *promoted* to godhood, the way pagan emperors were declared divine. But that is not the claim, and it never has been. Numbers 23:19 is about God's faithfulness: unlike a man, God does not lie and does not break His word. Hosea 11:9 is about God's mercy: unlike a man, God's anger does not consume in the way human rage does. Read in context, both verses contrast God's *character* with human frailty. Neither says that the eternal God lacks the freedom to make Himself present in our world in whatever way He chooses.

And in fact the Hebrew Scriptures are full of the strange, recurring nearness of God — the **Angel of Yahweh** who is somehow both distinct from Yahweh and identified as Yahweh (Genesis 16:7–13; Exodus 3:2–6; Judges 13); the figure Jacob wrestles, of whom Jacob says, "I have seen God face to face" (Genesis 32:30); the **Word** of Yahweh that comes and acts; the **Wisdom** of God present at creation (Proverbs 8); the glory that fills the temple. Israel's own Scriptures testify that the one God is not flat or simple in the way a single human person is. There is mystery in the oneness. Ancient Jewish interpreters knew it; some spoke of "two powers in heaven" — a tradition the rabbis later worked hard to rule out, precisely because some were drawing the conclusion that the New Testament would draw.

We are not inventing a category. We are noticing one that is already there in the Torah and the Prophets — and watching it come to a point.

The formula is planted

So here, at the headwaters, we have the formula and its meaning fixed for the rest of the Bible:

- **"I am he"** (*'ănî hû'*) is Yahweh's signature — His way of saying *I am the One, the only One*.
- It is bound to **exclusivity** ("no god with me"), to **life and death**, to **healing**, and to **unrivalled power**.
- It rests on the rock of the **Shema**: one God, one Lord.
- And it lives in a Scripture that already knows God can draw near in ways that strain a simple, solitary picture of His oneness.

Moses sang it. Now we go to the prophet who turned it into a refrain.

Chapter Three — Isaiah's Courtroom

The trial of the gods

Open the second half of Isaiah (chapters 40–55) and you walk into a courtroom. Israel is in exile. The empires look invincible. The idols of Babylon are paraded through the streets, gold-plated and impressive, and God's people are tempted to think Yahweh has lost. So God convenes a trial. He calls the gods of the nations to the witness stand and challenges them to prove they are gods at all:

"Let them announce to us what will happen... declare us things to come. Declare the things that are to come hereafter, that we may know that you are gods." — Isaiah 41:22–23 (WEB)

The test is simple: *If you are God, tell the future and bring it to pass. Only the true God knows the end from the beginning.* The idols, of course, say nothing. They are blocks of wood. And in the silence after the challenge, Yahweh identifies Himself — not once, but again and again — with the same two words Moses sang.

This is where "I am he" becomes a refrain. Watch it accumulate.

"I am he" — the First and the Last

"Who has worked and done it, calling the generations from the beginning? I, Yahweh, the first, and with the last, I am he." — Isaiah 41:4 (WEB)

The Hebrew ends *'ănî hû'* — "I am he." And it is joined to a staggering title: **the first and the last**. Yahweh stands before history begins and after it ends. Empires rise and fall inside Him like waves inside the sea. Remember this title — *the first and the last* — because we are going to meet it again, in the mouth of a risen man, in the last book of the Bible.

"That you may... believe that I am he"

Now comes the controlling text of this whole book. If you remember only one verse, remember this one:

"You are my witnesses," says Yahweh, "with my servant whom I have chosen; that you may know and believe me, and understand that I am he. Before me there was no God formed, neither will there be after me. I myself am Yahweh. Besides me there is no savior." — Isaiah 43:10–11 (WEB)

Read the verbs God stacks up. He wants His people to:

- **know**
- **believe**
- **understand**

— and the content of that knowing, believing, and understanding is: **"that I am he."** *Ani hu*. In the Septuagint: *hoti egō eimi* — "that I am." And the meaning is spelled out in the next lines:

- **"Before me there was no God formed, neither will there be after me."** Exclusivity again — the same note as Deuteronomy 32:39.
- **"Besides me there is no savior."** The One who says "I am he" is the only Savior. Salvation comes from Him, or it does not come at all.

Put a marker here, because in a few chapters a man in Jerusalem will tell a crowd that *unless they believe that He is "he," they will die in their sins* — and you will hear, underneath His words, this exact verse: *know, believe, understand, that I am he... besides me there is no savior*.

"I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions"

"I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions for my own sake; and I will not remember your sins." — Isaiah 43:25 (WEB)

Again the doubled, emphatic Hebrew — *ʾānōkî ʾānōkî hûʾ*, "I, I am he." And now the formula is bound to **the forgiveness of sins**. The One who is "He" is the One who wipes out transgressions and chooses to remember them no more.

Hold this beside a scene from the Gospels. A paralyzed man is lowered through a roof, and Jesus says, "Son, your sins are forgiven." The scribes are scandalized — and their theology is impeccable: "Why does this man speak blasphemies like that? Who can forgive sins but God alone?" (Mark 2:7). They are quoting, in effect, Isaiah 43:25. *Only "He" — only Yahweh — blots out transgressions*. And Jesus, knowing exactly what He is doing, heals the man to prove He has the authority to do the thing only "He" can do.

"Even to old age I am he"

"Even to old age I am he, and even to gray hairs I will carry you. I have made, and I will bear. Yes, I will carry, and will deliver." — Isaiah 46:4 (WEB)

The formula is not only cosmic; it is tender. The chapter before contrasts the idols of Babylon — which have to be *carried* on the backs of weary animals (Isaiah 46:1) — with Yahweh, who *carries His people*. Dead gods are a burden their worshipers must haul. The living God hoists His people onto His own shoulders from the womb to the grave. *I am he* — and being "He" means He carries you.

"I am he. I am the first. I am also the last."

"Listen to me, O Jacob, and Israel my called: I am he. I am the first. I am also the last. Yes, my hand has laid the foundation of the earth, and my right hand has spread out the heavens." — Isaiah 48:12–13 (WEB)

The formula, the title, and the act of creation are fused into one sentence. *I am he. I am the first and the last. My hand made the earth and the heavens.* The One who is "He" is the Creator of everything, with no helper and no rival:

"I am Yahweh, who makes all things; who alone stretches out the heavens; who spreads out the earth by myself." — Isaiah 44:24 (WEB)

"I am the first, and I am the last; and besides me there is no God." — Isaiah 44:6 (WEB)

Underline "alone" and "by myself" and "besides me there is no God." Isaiah could not be more emphatic that Yahweh created everything **without any second being**. This is going to become one of the most important objections in Chapter Six — *if Yahweh made everything alone, how can the New Testament say the Son made everything?* — and the answer, when it comes, is the hinge of the whole question.

"My people shall know my name"

"Therefore my people shall know my name. Therefore they shall know in that day that I am he who speaks. Behold, it is I." — Isaiah 52:6 (WEB)

The refrain reaches forward. There is a "day" coming when God's people will **know His name** and recognize **the One who speaks** — *I am he who speaks*. The very next chapter is Isaiah 53, the song of the Suffering Servant, wounded for our transgressions, by whose stripes we are healed. Isaiah binds together, in adjacent breaths, the One who says "I am he who speaks" and the Servant who is "pierced for our transgressions." Keep that nearness in mind.

"I am God, and there is no other"

Finally, the great evangelistic appeal of the courtroom — addressed not just to Israel but to the whole earth:

"Look to me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth; for I am God, and there is no other... to me every knee will bow, every tongue will swear." — Isaiah 45:22–23 (WEB)

Mark this one heavily. Yahweh says that **every knee in all the earth will bow to Him**, and to Him alone, *because* there is no other God. To bow the knee to anyone else as God would be idolatry. So when the New Testament takes this exact verse and says that every knee will bow and every tongue confess **at the name of Jesus** (Philippians 2:10–11), it is doing one of two things: committing blasphemy, or telling us who Jesus is. There is no middle path. We will return to it in Chapter Five.

The refrain, gathered

Step back and hear the whole chorus of Isaiah's courtroom. To say "I am he" — *ani hu, egō eimi* — is to be:

- the **First and the Last** (41:4; 44:6; 48:12),
- the **only God**, with no other formed before or after (43:10),
- the **only Savior** (43:11; 45:22),
- the **One who blots out sins** (43:25),
- the **One who carries His people** (46:4),
- the **Creator who made everything alone** (44:24; 48:13),
- the **One whose future-telling proves His deity** (41:22–23; 46:9–10),
- the **One to whom every knee will bow** (45:23).

That is the meaning of the formula when Isaiah lays down his pen. Now turn the page four hundred years, walk into a Galilean synagogue and a Jerusalem temple court, and listen for two words.

Chapter Four — The Formula on the Lips of Jesus

A carpenter starts saying it

The Gospel of John was written by a Jew steeped in Isaiah. And in John, Jesus says *egō eimi* — "I am he" — in the absolute, predicate-less way that, in the Greek Bible, belonged to Yahweh alone. He does it at least seven times in the bare, ringing form, and each time the context reaches back to the courtroom of Isaiah.

Let us hear them in order, and watch the temperature rise.

"It is I. Don't be afraid." (on the water)

Before the controversies, there is a quiet one. The disciples are in a boat at night, terrified, when Jesus comes walking on the sea — the sea that, in Israel's Scriptures, only God treads (Job 9:8; Psalm 77:19). He says:

"It is I. Don't be afraid." — John 6:20 (WEB; Greek: egō eimi, mē phobeisthe)

"It is I" translates *egō eimi*. "Don't be afraid" is what God and His messengers say when divine glory breaks in. Mark tells the same scene and adds that He "intended to pass by them" (Mark 6:48–50) — the same words used when Yahweh's glory "passed by" Moses (Exodus 33:19–22) and Elijah (1 Kings 19:11). A man walks on the water God walks on, says the words God says, in a scene shaped like a divine appearance. The first *egō eimi* is on the sea.

"Unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins." (John 8:24)

Now the temple courts, and the central text. Jesus is in a sharp exchange with the religious leaders, and He says:

"I said therefore to you that you will die in your sins; for unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins." — John 8:24 (WEB; Greek: ean... mē pisteusēte hoti egō eimi)

The English supplies "he" because the sentence is incomplete without it — *unless you believe that I am... what?* Jesus does not finish it with an ordinary predicate. Not "unless you believe that I am the Messiah." Not "a prophet." Not "a good teacher." Just: **"that I am he."** *Hoti egō*

eimi.

Lay it beside Isaiah 43:10, and the echo is unmistakable:

Isaiah 43:10 (Yahweh)	John 8:24 (Jesus)
"that you may know and believe me"	" unless you believe "
"and understand that I am he "	" that I am he "
"besides me there is no savior "	"you will die in your sins "

In Isaiah, Yahweh wants His people to *believe that I am he* because *besides me there is no savior*. In John, Jesus warns that *unless you believe that I am he*, you will *die in your sins* — that is, unsaved. The logic is identical, because the claim is identical. He is saying: *I am the "He" of Isaiah. I am the only Savior. Recognize Me, or perish in your sins, because there is no other to recognize.*

"Then you will know that I am he." (John 8:28)

A few sentences later He says it again, and now He ties it to the cross:

"When you have lifted up the Son of Man, then you will know that I am he, and that I do nothing of myself, but as my Father taught me, I say these things." — John 8:28 (WEB)

"Lifted up" is John's word for the crucifixion (John 3:14; 12:32–33). So Jesus says: the moment you raise Me on a Roman cross, *that* is when you will know that **I am he**. The deity is revealed not in spite of the cross but *through* it. This is one of the most staggering claims in all of Scripture: the "He" of Isaiah will be most clearly seen when He is hanging on a tree outside the city wall.

"Before Abraham came into existence, I AM." (John 8:58)

The chapter reaches its peak. Jesus says:

"Most certainly, I tell you, before Abraham came into existence, I AM." — John 8:58 (WEB; Greek: prin Abraam genesthai egō eimi)

Notice the grammar, because it is deliberate and a little jarring. He does not say, "before Abraham was, I *was*" (which would be *ēmēn*, the natural past tense). He says, "before

Abraham *came into being* [past], I AM [present]." Abraham *became*; Jesus *is*. Abraham belongs to the world of things that begin; Jesus speaks from the timeless present of the One who simply *is* — the One who told Moses, "I AM WHO I AM" (Exodus 3:14), and who says through Isaiah, "I am he... I am the first and the last."

And the crowd's reaction removes all doubt about how they heard it:

"Therefore they took up stones to throw at him." — John 8:59 (WEB)

Nobody picks up stones because a teacher claimed to be old. They picked up stones because, under the Law, the penalty for blasphemy — for a man making himself out to be God — was stoning (Leviticus 24:16). They understood Him perfectly. They thought it was blasphemy. The only question left is whether they were right that He said it, or right that it was false. John's whole Gospel is the answer to the second question.

"That... you may believe that I am he." (John 13:19)

In the upper room, on the last night, Jesus tells His friends what is about to happen, and gives the reason:

"From now on, I tell you before it happens, that when it happens, you may believe that I am he." — John 13:19 (WEB)

This may be the most quietly devastating of them all, because it is pure Isaiah. Remember the test in the courtroom: *the true God proves He is God by telling the future before it happens*.

"Declare the things that are to come... that we may know that you are gods" (Isaiah 41:22–23). And in Isaiah 43:10 — "that you may... believe me, and understand that I am he." Jesus now does exactly what Yahweh does and says exactly what Yahweh says: *I am telling you the future in advance, so that when it comes to pass you will believe that I am he*. He is not merely predicting. He is identifying.

"I am he." (and the soldiers fall) — John 18:5–6

Finally, the garden. The arresting party arrives with lanterns and weapons. Jesus asks whom they seek. "Jesus of Nazareth," they say. He answers:

"I am he." ... "When therefore he said to them, 'I am he,' they went backward and fell to the ground." — John 18:5–6 (WEB; Greek: egō eimi)

We must be careful and fair here, because honesty is our policy. On the surface, "I am he" is the natural answer to "whom do you seek?" — "That's me." It need not, by itself, be a divine

claim. But John has spent his whole Gospel training us to hear these two words a certain way (8:24, 8:28, 8:58, 13:19), and now he records something that does not happen when a man simply says "that's me": an armed cohort **staggers backward and collapses to the ground**. John wants us to see that the One being arrested is not the victim of the scene but its Lord — that the words "I am he" carry a power the soldiers feel in their knees. He is not seized; He surrenders. The "He" of Isaiah hands Himself over.

The Synoptics say it too

A common objection — we will treat it fully in Chapter Six — is that this high view of Jesus is found "only in John," the latest Gospel, and so was invented decades after the fact. But the formula is in the earlier Gospels as well, at the highest-stakes moments.

On the sea, in Mark's account: "Cheer up! It is I [*egō eimi*]! Don't be afraid" (Mark 6:50).

And at His trial, under oath, when the high priest asks the direct question — "Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?" — Mark records Jesus' answer:

"Jesus said, 'I am [egō eimi]. You will see the Son of Man sitting at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of the sky.'" — Mark 14:62 (WEB)

He answers "I am" — *egō eimi* — and immediately fuses two of the most exalted texts in the Hebrew Bible: the Son of Man who comes on the clouds and is given everlasting dominion (Daniel 7:13–14) and the Lord who sits at God's right hand (Psalm 110:1). And the high priest's response is the same as the crowd's in John 8: he tears his robes and cries, "Blasphemy!" (Mark 14:63–64). In the earliest Gospel, at the decisive moment, Jesus says the formula, claims the throne of God, and is condemned for blasphemy. The "only in John" objection does not survive contact with Mark 14.

What the carpenter claimed

So the pattern is complete and it is not subtle. The same two words — *ani hu* in the Hebrew of Yahweh, *egō eimi* in the Greek of Yahweh — fall from the lips of Jesus:

- on the sea God alone treads,
- as the ground of salvation ("unless you believe that I am he"),
- revealed through the cross ("then you will know that I am he"),
- in the timeless present ("before Abraham was, I AM"),
- as the proof-by-prophecy of Isaiah's courtroom ("that you may believe that I am he"),

- with power that knocks an armed cohort to the earth,
- and under oath, fused to the throne of God, on pain of death.

He was not vague, and His hearers were not confused. They knew exactly what He was claiming. They picked up stones; they tore their robes; they nailed Him to the wood. The only question they left for us is the one this book exists to answer: **Who is the "He"?**

Before we answer it, let us make sure the rest of the New Testament agrees — because if John and Mark put the formula in Jesus' mouth but no one else understood Him that way, we would have a puzzle. In fact, the whole New Testament sings the same note.

Chapter Five — The One Isaiah Saw

The widening witness

If Jesus really claimed to be the "He" of Isaiah, we would expect His first followers — all of them Jews, raised on the Shema, who would rather die than worship a creature — to either reject Him as a blasphemer or worship Him as the Lord. There is no honest in-between. What we actually find, in the earliest Christian writings, is that they worshiped Him — and they did it by taking the most exclusive, Yahweh-only texts of the Hebrew Bible and applying them to Jesus, on purpose, without apology. This chapter gathers the evidence.

The Word was God

John opens his Gospel by reaching behind Abraham, behind creation, to "the beginning":

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.... All things were made through him. Without him, nothing was made that has been made." — John 1:1, 3 (WEB)

Two things are held together that seem to pull apart. The Word is **distinct** from God — "with God" (Greek: *pros ton theon*, face to face with God). And the Word **is** God — "the Word was God" (*theos ēn ho logos*). This is the whole mystery in one sentence: distinction *and* identity. The Son is not the Father (He is "with" Him); the Son is fully God (He "was God"). And verse 14: "The Word became flesh, and lived among us." The One who was God, and was with God, and made all things, is the One who pitched His tent among us in Jesus.

(We will deal in Chapter Six with the Jehovah's Witness rendering "the Word was a *god*." For now, simply notice the claim John is making: the same Word who *was God* is the Word who *became flesh*.)

Isaiah saw *His* glory

Here is one of the most breathtaking verses in the New Testament, and one of the least quoted. In Isaiah 6, the prophet sees "the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lifted up," surrounded by seraphim crying "Holy, holy, holy is Yahweh of Armies" (Isaiah 6:1–3). It is the throne-room of Yahweh in His unapproachable glory. John quotes from that very chapter and then says this:

"Isaiah said these things when he saw his glory, and spoke of him." — John 12:41 (WEB)

Whose glory did Isaiah see on that throne? In context, John says: **Jesus**'. The glory Isaiah beheld — the glory of Yahweh of Armies, thrice-holy, enthroned — John identifies as *the glory of Christ*. The One on the throne in Isaiah 6 is the One who walked out of Nazareth. You cannot get a higher claim than that, and John makes it in a single, almost offhand sentence.

Every knee — the verse that cannot be shared

Recall Isaiah 45:23, where Yahweh swears that "every knee will bow" to Him, *because* "I am God, and there is no other" (45:22). It is the most jealously exclusive verse imaginable: God will share His worship with no one. Now read what Paul, a former Pharisee, writes about Jesus:

"Therefore God also highly exalted him, and gave to him the name which is above every name; that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of those in heaven, those on earth, and those under the earth, and that every tongue should confess that Jesus is Lord, to the glory of God the Father." — Philippians 2:9–11 (WEB)

Paul takes the universal-worship text that Yahweh reserved for Himself alone, and says it is fulfilled **at the name of Jesus**. "The name which is above every name" — in a Jewish frame, that name is *YHWH*, "the LORD." Paul says God gave Jesus *that* name, and that bowing to Jesus as Lord is "to the glory of God the Father." Far from competing with the Father, confessing Jesus as Yahweh-Lord *glorifies* the Father. This is the divine identity, shared, without a second God being added. A Pharisee wrote that. Let that sink in.

The heavens are the work of *Your* hands

Remember Isaiah's insistence that Yahweh made everything **alone**, "by myself" (Isaiah 44:24). Now hear the letter to the Hebrews, which addresses these words — originally spoken to Yahweh in Psalm 102 — directly to the Son:

"You, Lord, in the beginning, laid the foundation of the earth. The heavens are the works of your hands.... But you are the same. Your years will not fail." — Hebrews 1:10, 12 (WEB)

The author of Hebrews quotes a Psalm sung *to Yahweh the Creator* and says it is spoken **to the Son** (Hebrews 1:8 — "of the Son he says... 'Your throne, O God, is forever'"). The Son is the Creator who laid the earth's foundation and whose years never fail. This is the answer to

the riddle we flagged in Chapter Three: Isaiah says Yahweh created alone; the New Testament says the Son created all things (John 1:3; Colossians 1:16; Hebrews 1:2, 10). These are not two creators. The Son is *within* the identity of the one Creator. When Isaiah says "I made everything by myself," and John says "all things were made through the Word," they are not contradicting; they are telling us something about who the one God is.

The Shema itself, opened around Jesus

The most astonishing example is what Paul does with the Shema. Watch carefully. Deuteronomy 6:4 says: "Yahweh our God, Yahweh is one." Paul takes that one confession and writes:

"Yet to us there is one God, the Father, of whom are all things, and we for him; and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things, and we live through him." — 1 Corinthians 8:6 (WEB)

A Jew would normally never split the Shema. But Paul takes its two key words — *God (theos)* and *Lord (kyrios)*, the Greek that stands for *YHWH* — and arranges them around two persons: "one God, the Father" and "one Lord, Jesus Christ." He is not adding a second deity beside Yahweh. He is saying that the one Lord God of the Shema includes the Father *and* the Son. The most monotheistic sentence in the Bible has been opened up to make room for Jesus — by a man who was trained to guard it with his life.

The first and the last, who died and lives

Finally, return to the title we have been tracking since Isaiah 41:4 — "I am the first, and I am the last; and besides me there is no God" (Isaiah 44:6). In the last book of the Bible, the risen Jesus says:

"Don't be afraid. I am the first and the last, and the Living one. I was dead, and behold, I am alive forever and ever." — Revelation 1:17–18 (WEB)

"I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End." — Revelation 22:13 (WEB)

The exclusive title of Yahweh — *the first and the last, besides whom there is no God* — is claimed by the One who "was dead" and is "alive forever." The One crucified outside Jerusalem speaks Isaiah's signature as His own. *I am the first and the last*. And the worship of heaven proves the point: the Lamb receives the very same worship as the One on the throne — "to him who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb, be the blessing, the honor, the glory, and

the dominion, forever" (Revelation 5:13). In the throne-room where no creature may be worshiped, the Lamb is worshiped beside the Father, and heaven is not scandalized.

The witness, gathered

So the formula was not a misfire that only John caught. The whole New Testament, written by Jews who would not bow to an idol, does the same thing in a dozen ways:

- The **Word** who "was God" and made all things became flesh (John 1).
- The **glory Isaiah saw** on Yahweh's throne was Christ's glory (John 12:41).
- The **knee that bows only to Yahweh** bows at the name of Jesus (Philippians 2 / Isaiah 45).
- The **Creator who made everything alone** is addressed as the Son (Hebrews 1 / Psalm 102 / Isaiah 44).
- The **Shema's one Lord** is opened to include Jesus (1 Corinthians 8:6 / Deuteronomy 6:4).
- The **first and the last, besides whom there is no God**, is the Lamb who died and lives (Revelation 1, 22 / Isaiah 44).

This is what it looks like when monotheists conclude that the "He" of Isaiah has come in person. They did not abandon the Shema. They discovered who the one Lord is.

Now we owe you the hard part. Every honest reader has objections piling up by now. Let us face them — all of them — without a single cheap shot.

Chapter Six — Honest Objections

This chapter is the conscience of the book. A case that cannot survive its best opponents is not worth believing. So we will state each objection as strongly as we can — the way its own defenders would state it — and then answer it honestly. Some of these objections are weak. Several are genuinely serious and have been pressed by brilliant people. None will be mocked.

Objection 1: "egō eimi just means 'I am.' It proves nothing."

The objection. The Greek *egō eimi* is the most ordinary phrase in the world. In John 9:9, the healed blind man says *egō eimi* — "I'm the one" — and no one thinks he is claiming deity. To build a doctrine on two common words is special pleading.

The answer. This objection is correct as far as it goes, and we conceded it in Chapter One. Grammar alone proves nothing. But the argument of this book was never "the words *egō eimi* are magic." It is that a **specific, repeated, absolute use** of the formula, *in contexts that match Isaiah point for point*, is a deliberate claim. The healed man in John 9 says *egō eimi* with an obvious predicate ("the man you mean — that's me"). Jesus says it **absolutely and dangling** — "unless you believe that I am," "before Abraham was, I am" — in scenes about salvation, pre-existence, prophecy, and the throne of God, and His hearers respond by trying to **execute Him for blasphemy**. Nobody reached for stones when the blind man spoke. The difference is not the two words; it is everything around them. Context is not a loophole. Context is how language works.

Objection 2: "This is just Exodus 3:14, and that's a stretch."

The objection. Christians love to say Jesus' "I am" echoes "I AM WHO I AM" in Exodus 3:14. But the Greek of Exodus 3:14 in the Septuagint is *egō eimi ho ōn* — "I am THE BEING / THE ONE WHO IS" — and God's name there is given as *ho ōn*, "the One who is," not bare *egō eimi*. So the link is shaky.

The answer. This is a fair and even helpful objection, and the honest response is: *Exodus 3:14 is real but it is not the main key*. The sharper background is precisely the one this book has traced — the "I am he" (*ani hu*) refrain of Deuteronomy 32 and Isaiah 41–52, where the Septuagint renders the formula with the **bare, absolute egō eimi** that Jesus actually uses.

We are not leaning on Exodus and hoping no one checks the Greek. We are leaning on Isaiah, where the Greek matches Jesus' usage exactly. Exodus 3:14 stands behind it all as the great "I AM" of the burning bush — and John 8:58's jarring "before Abraham was, I AM" does evoke it — but the precise verbal fingerprint is Isaiah's *egō eimi*, not Exodus' *ho ōn*. Pointing this out actually *strengthens* the case, because it shows we have done our homework and are not depending on the weakest link.

Objection 3 (the Jewish reader): "This breaks the Shema. God is one, and He is not a man."

The objection. The bedrock of the Torah is "Yahweh is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4). God explicitly says He is not a man (Numbers 23:19; Hosea 11:9) and that He will not give His glory to another (Isaiah 42:8; 48:11). To call a crucified Galilean "Yahweh" is, by definition, the idolatry the Torah was given to prevent.

The answer. This is the most important objection in the book, and it deserves more than a paragraph; it deserves the whole book's respect. Three things must be said.

First, the New Testament does **not** claim two Gods or a man-made-into-a-god. It claims that the one Yahweh of the Shema has made Himself known as Father, Son, and Spirit — one God, one identity, eternally. Christians recite "Yahweh is one" with you and mean it. The dispute is not *whether* God is one but *who* the one God is.

Second, your own Scriptures contain the seeds of this mystery — and ancient Judaism knew it. The **Angel of Yahweh** is both sent by Yahweh and *is* Yahweh, receiving worship and speaking as God (Genesis 16:7–13; Exodus 3:2–6; Judges 13:21–22). Jacob wrestles a "man" and names the place "Peniel," "for I have seen God face to face" (Genesis 32:30). Daniel sees "one like a son of man" who comes on the clouds and receives **everlasting dominion and worship** from all peoples — worship that, in your Scriptures, belongs to God alone (Daniel 7:13–14). The Wisdom of God is "beside him, a master workman" at creation (Proverbs 8:30). The rabbis of the Talmud explicitly debated and condemned a view they called **"two powers in heaven,"** which tells us that *some Jews were reading these texts exactly the way the New Testament does* — and the authorities had to rule it out. We are not importing a foreign idea. We are standing inside an old and serious Jewish question.

Third, "God will not give His glory to another" (Isaiah 42:8) is the very reason this matters. If Jesus is a creature, then Christians are idolaters and you are right to refuse. But if Jesus is the "He" of Isaiah — Yahweh come in the flesh — then bowing to Him is not giving God's glory to *another*; it is giving God's glory to **God**, as Philippians 2:11 says, "to the glory of God the Father." The whole question reduces to identity. We ask only this: read Isaiah 43:10–11 and

John 8:24 side by side, and ask whether the carpenter was quoting your God's signature. We will stand with you on the oneness of God to our last breath. We simply believe the One has a face, and that Isaiah saw it (John 12:41).

Objection 4 (the Muslim reader): "Jesus never said, 'I am God, worship me.' And the text has been changed."

The objection. The Qur'an honors Jesus (Isa) as a mighty prophet and the Messiah, born of a virgin, but insists he is not divine; to associate partners with God (*shirk*) is the one unforgivable sin, and *tawhid* — God's absolute oneness — is everything. Where does Jesus ever plainly say, "I am God; worship me"? Moreover, the Gospels were corrupted (*tahrif*); the divine-Jesus passages were added later.

The answer. We share more than is often admitted: we, too, reject idolatry; we, too, confess one God; we, too, honor the virgin birth and the sinlessness and the miracles of the Messiah. So hear this as from a friend.

On "Jesus never said it": The expectation that Jesus must say the exact sentence "I am God, worship me" misunderstands how He revealed Himself. He did something deeper than slogan. He took the **personal signature of the God of Israel** — "I am he," the words by which Yahweh declares "there is no god beside me" (Deuteronomy 32:39; Isaiah 43:10) — and applied it to Himself, in His own people's holy language, in contexts about salvation and creation and the throne of God. His hearers understood Him so well that they tried to stone Him for blasphemy (John 8:58–59) and finally crucified Him for claiming the throne of God under oath (Mark 14:62–64). A man does not get executed for blasphemy for saying "I am only a prophet." He also **received worship** and did not refuse it (John 9:38; 20:28, where Thomas says to Him, "My Lord and my God!") and Jesus accepts it and blesses those who will believe likewise). He forgave sins — which, His critics rightly said, "God alone" can do (Mark 2:7). The claim is everywhere; it is simply made in the idiom of Isaiah rather than a modern creedal formula.

On corruption (tahrif): This is a historical claim, and history can be checked. We possess thousands of New Testament manuscripts, in Greek and in early translations, spread across the ancient world — including substantial copies that predate Islam by centuries (for example, the great fourth-century codices, and papyri of John from the second and third centuries). When we compare them, the high view of Christ — the "I am he" sayings of John, the worship of the Lamb in Revelation, the hymn of Philipians 2 — is present in the **earliest** witnesses, on every continent where the church spread, with no trace of a primitive "merely-a-prophet" version that was later overwritten. There is no manuscript anywhere that shows John 8 or

Mark 14 being edited to *insert* a divine claim. If the divinity of Christ were a later corruption, it left no fingerprints in a vast, decentralized, multilingual manuscript tradition that no one had the power to coordinate. The evidence runs the other way: the deity of Jesus is in the oldest layer we can reach. We say this not to score a point but because you deserve to weigh the actual evidence, not a rumor about it.

We will never insult the Prophet, the Qur'an, or you. We ask only that you let Jesus speak in His own words, in their own context, and consider that the "He" of Isaiah may have come nearer than you were told.

Objection 5 (the Jehovah's Witness): "John 1:1 says 'a god,' and John 8:58 should read 'I have been.'"

The objection. The New World Translation renders John 1:1 "the Word was a god" (because *theos* lacks the article), and John 8:58 "before Abraham came to be, I **have been**" (taking *egō eimi* as a past-continuous). Jesus is God's first and mightiest creation (identified with Michael the archangel), not Almighty God; he is "a god," a divine being, but not Jehovah.

The answer. Both renderings collapse under the Greek and the context.

John 1:1. The claim that anarthrous *theos* ("God" without "the") must mean "a god" is a grammatical mistake. In Greek, a predicate noun placed **before** the verb (here, *theos ēn ho logos*) is regularly definite or qualitative without the article — this is a well-known feature of the language (often discussed under "Colwell's rule" and, more precisely, the qualitative force of pre-verbal predicate nouns). John omits the article precisely to **avoid saying the Word is the same person as the Father** (which "the God" would imply) while still affirming the Word is **fully, qualitatively God**. Tellingly, the NWT itself translates the *same* anarthrous *theos* as "God," not "a god," in other verses (for example, John 1:6, 12, 18) — the "a god" rendering is applied only where it suits the conclusion. And the context forbids "a god": the Word made "all things" (1:3), which Isaiah says Yahweh did **alone** (44:24). A created "a god" who then creates all things is a contradiction in terms; Isaiah leaves no room for a junior deity.

John 8:58. Rendering *egō eimi* as "I have been" does not fit the grammar of the contrast. Jesus deliberately sets a **past** event for Abraham (*genesthai*, "came into being") against a **present** state for Himself (*eimi*, "I am"). "Before Abraham came to be, I have been" blurs the very contrast that gives the sentence its force; the natural and intended sense is the timeless present "I AM." Above all, the crowd's reaction settles it: they "took up stones" (8:59). No one stones a man for claiming to have lived a long time. They stoned for blasphemy — because they heard a creature claiming the eternal self-existence and the very formula of Yahweh.

On "a god" / *Michael*. Scripture will not allow a middle category of "a mighty divine creature who is worshiped." Yahweh says, "Besides me there is no God" (Isaiah 44:6) and "I am God, and there is no other" (45:22). Either Jesus is a creature — in which case the worship He receives (Hebrews 1:6; Revelation 5:13–14; John 20:28) is idolatry and must stop — or He is, with the Father, the one God. There is no "a god" Jesus in the Bible of Isaiah. You love the name and the kingdom; follow the Greek and the context where they actually lead, and you will find that the One you call "a god" is the "He" beside whom there is no other.

Objection 6 (the historian / skeptic): "High Christology was invented late, and the Gospels contradict each other."

The objection. The divine Jesus appears "only in John," written around 90–100 AD, two generations after Jesus. The earlier Gospels show a more human, prophetic figure. The doctrine of Christ's deity evolved slowly and was only fixed by church councils centuries later (Nicaea, 325 AD). It is legend, not history.

The answer. The timeline is the opposite of what the objection assumes. Set John aside entirely and the high view is still there — and **earlier**.

- **Mark**, the earliest Gospel, has Jesus forgiving sins as only God can (2:5–7), walking on the sea saying *egō eimi* (6:50), and at His trial answering "I am" and claiming the throne and the clouds of Daniel 7 (14:62), for which He is condemned as a blasphemer. That is not a "merely human" Jesus.
- **Paul's letters** predate all four Gospels (written c. 48–62 AD, within 15–30 years of the crucifixion). And in them we already find the highest Christology imaginable: the Shema reworked around Jesus (1 Corinthians 8:6, c. 53–55 AD), and the hymn of Philippians 2:6–11 applying Isaiah 45:23's universal worship to Jesus. Most scholars across the spectrum regard the Philippians passage as a **hymn Paul is quoting** — meaning it was already being sung in the churches *before* Paul wrote it down. The worship of Jesus as Lord is not a fourth-century development; it is the earliest Christian devotion we can document, traceable to within a few years of the cross.
- **1 Corinthians 15:3–7**, which Paul calls a tradition he "received" and "delivered," is widely dated by critical scholars to within a handful of years of the crucifixion — the resurrection proclamation is primitive bedrock, not late legend.

Nicaea (325) did not *invent* the deity of Christ; it *defended* what the church had confessed and sung from the start, against a new teaching (Arianism) that the Son was a creature. Councils put fences around old beliefs; they do not manufacture them.

As for "contradiction with the Synoptics": the Synoptics are quieter and more allusive than John, but they say the same thing in their own register — forgiveness of sins, lordship over nature and the Sabbath and demons, the trial confession, the worship He accepts. John turns up the volume and states plainly what the others show. Different emphasis is not contradiction. Four witnesses describing the same person from different angles is what truthful testimony looks like.

You need not believe in advance that the texts are inspired to test this objection. You need only read Mark 14 and 1 Corinthians 8 and Philippians 2 and ask whether "invented centuries later" can survive them. It cannot.

Objection 7 (the Oneness / modalist reader): "Then Jesus is the Father."

The objection. If Jesus is fully God, and there is only one God, then Jesus simply *is* the Father — "Father," "Son," and "Spirit" are three modes or masks of one solitary person, not three real, eternal distinctions.

The answer. This honors the oneness but flattens the texts. John says the Word "was **with** God" and "**was** God" (1:1) — distinction and identity together; you cannot be "with" yourself in that sense. The Son prays to the Father (John 17), and they love each other "before the foundation of the world" (17:24) — a real "I-Thou" that predates creation. At the baptism, the Son stands in the water, the Spirit descends, and the Father speaks from heaven (Mark 1:9–11) — three at once, not one person changing costumes. The Son is sent *by* the Father and sends the Spirit *from* the Father. So the biblical confession is neither "three Gods" (tritheism) nor "one God wearing three masks" (modalism), but **one God who eternally exists as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit** — three distinct persons, one undivided divine being. "I am he" is spoken by the Son, who is not the Father, and who is, with the Father and the Spirit, the one Yahweh.

Objection 8: "Doesn't Isaiah explicitly *exclude* Jesus? 'I made everything alone; there is no other.'"

The objection. Isaiah is the very book you lean on, and it slams the door: "I, Yahweh... alone... by myself" (44:24); "besides me there is no God" (44:6); "I will not give my glory to another" (48:11). Those words exclude *anyone* else — including Jesus — from deity.

The answer. They exclude every **rival** and every **creature** — every "other" God *outside* Yahweh, every idol, every pretender. The question is whether the Son is an "other" *outside*

Yahweh, or is *within* the identity of the one Yahweh. The New Testament's answer is the second, and it answers Isaiah on Isaiah's own terms:

- Isaiah: Yahweh made all things **alone** (44:24). New Testament: all things were made **through the Son** (John 1:3; Colossians 1:16; Hebrews 1:10). If the Son were an "other," this would be a flat contradiction. Since the New Testament presents the Son as sharing the one Creator's identity, it is not a contradiction but a disclosure: the "alone" of Yahweh *includes* the Son and the Spirit.
- Isaiah: "I will not give my glory to **another**" (42:8; 48:11). New Testament: the Son has the glory "which I had with you before the world existed" (John 17:5) — not glory *given to another*, but the Son's *own* shared glory, the glory Isaiah saw on the throne (John 12:41).
- Isaiah: "to me every knee will bow" (45:23). New Testament: "at the name of Jesus every knee will bow... **to the glory of God the Father**" (Philippians 2:10–11) — worship of the Son that *glorifies* the Father, not worship stolen by a rival.

So Isaiah does not exclude Jesus. Isaiah excludes everyone who is **not** Yahweh — and the New Testament's whole claim is that the Son is not someone other than Yahweh, but the eternal "He" come in person. The objection assumes the conclusion (that the Son is an "other") that the entire New Testament denies.

The objections, weighed

We have not dodged one. The grammar objection is true but beside the point, because the case rests on pattern, not on bare words. The Exodus objection is fair and actually sharpens the argument toward Isaiah. The Jewish objection is the weightiest and is answered on the Hebrew Bible's own ground — the Angel of Yahweh, the Son of Man, "two powers." The Muslim objection meets a Jesus who claimed deity in Isaiah's idiom and a manuscript record with no trace of the alleged corruption. The Jehovah's Witness renderings fail the Greek and the context. The "invented late" theory is buried by Mark, by pre-Pauline hymns, and by a creed Paul "received" within a few years of the cross. Modalism flattens the persons; the "Isaiah excludes Jesus" objection assumes the very thing in dispute.

None of this *forces* faith. Evidence never does; the heart is involved, and the heart can refuse what the mind has seen. But it clears the road. There is no honest exit that lets you keep the texts and avoid the question. So we return, one last time, to the question that has been waiting since page one.

Chapter Seven — Who Is the He?

Standing where we started

We began with a small word that almost everyone walks past: **He**. We have followed it now from the oldest song in Israel to the throne-room of Revelation. Let us gather the whole thread into one hand.

In the **Song of Moses**, Yahweh says: "See now that I, even I, am he. There is no god with me. I kill and I make alive" (Deuteronomy 32:39).

In **Isaiah's courtroom**, He says it until it becomes a refrain: "that you may... believe... that I am he... besides me there is no savior" (43:10–11); "I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions" (43:25); "I am he. I am the first. I am also the last" (48:12); "to me every knee will bow" (45:23).

In the **Gospels**, the same two words — *ani hu* in Hebrew, *egō eimi* in Greek — fall from the lips of a Galilean: "unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins" (John 8:24); "before Abraham came into existence, I AM" (8:58); "that... you may believe that I am he" (13:19); "I am" — and the soldiers fall (18:5–6); "I am," fused to the throne of God, under oath (Mark 14:62).

And in the **rest of the New Testament**, His first followers — Jews to the bone — take Yahweh's most exclusive words and lay them on Jesus: the Word who *was God* and made all things (John 1); the glory Isaiah saw, which was *His* (John 12:41); the knee that bows only to God, bowing to Him (Philippians 2); the first and the last who *died and is alive forever* (Revelation 1).

So the question is no longer vague. It is not, "Did Jesus exist?" or "Was Jesus a good man?" or even "Was Jesus the Messiah?" The question forced on us by His own words, in His own people's holy language, is exactly this:

Who is the "He" that Jesus said you must believe Him to be — or die in your sins?

The Bible gives one answer, and it is not quiet. The One who speaks is the eternal **Word**. The One who speaks is the **Creator**. The One who speaks is the only **Savior**. The One who speaks is the **Lord whom Isaiah saw, high and lifted up**. The One who speaks is the **First and the Last**. He is not a second God beside Yahweh. He is not a created "a god." He is not the Father wearing a mask. He is the eternal **Son** — and with the Father and the Spirit, the one Yahweh of the Shema. He is the "He."

Why it cannot be left as an opinion

C. S. Lewis put the edge on it as well as anyone: a man who said the things Jesus said is not left to us as merely a great moral teacher. A great moral teacher does not take the personal signature of the God of Israel and apply it to himself unless he is either right, or a blasphemer, or insane. The category "wonderful human teacher who never claimed deity" is the one option the texts will not allow, because the texts will not stop saying *egō eimi*.

And notice *why* Jesus said it. Not to win an argument. He attached the formula to a warning of unbearable tenderness and weight: **"unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins"** (John 8:24). Recognizing who He is, it turns out, is not a theological luxury. It is the difference between dying in your sins and being saved out of them — because, as Isaiah said in the same breath as the formula, "besides me there is no savior" (43:11). If Jesus is the "He," then He is the only Savior, and there is no other to turn to. That is not a threat. It is a rescue thrown to people who are drowning and do not always know it.

To each reader, a word

To the doubter and the skeptic: you have read the texts now, in their own languages and contexts. You owe yourself the honesty of facing what they actually claim instead of a cartoon of it. You do not have to manufacture faith by force. But you can do the one thing the formula keeps asking: *consider that He is "He."* Ask Him, if He is there, to show you. Honest seekers have been answered before. "You will seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart" (Jeremiah 29:13).

To our Jewish friend: we have not asked you to leave your Scriptures; we have begged you to read them — Deuteronomy 32, Isaiah 43, Daniel 7. The "He" is *your* God's signature. We believe the One you have worshiped without a face has shown His face, and that Isaiah saw it. Test it on the texts you have loved your whole life.

To our Muslim friend: you confess God is one and that He sent the Messiah, born of a virgin, who healed and raised the dead. We ask only that you let that Messiah speak His own words. The One who said "I am he" in the idiom of Isaiah is nearer and greater than you were told — not a partner *added* to God, but the one God come to save.

To our Jehovah's Witness friend: you have followed the name this far. Follow the Greek and the context the rest of the way — through John 1:3 and Isaiah 44:24, through the stones picked up in John 8:59, through the worship the Lamb receives in Revelation 5 — and you will find the "He" beside whom there is no other.

To the Christian: this is your ground. The deity of Christ is not a fragile inference; it is a thread woven through the whole of Scripture, Genesis to Revelation. Stand on it. And let it do to you what it did to Thomas, who touched the wounds and could only fall and say, "My Lord and my God!" (John 20:28).

The end of the matter

The whole Bible bends toward one promise, the promise this ministry is named for:

"For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea." — Habakkuk 2:14 (WEB)

The knowledge of His glory. The glory Isaiah saw on the throne. The glory that has a face. The glory of the One who said, on a hillside, in a temple court, on the sea, and in a garden:

"I am he."

Yahweh said it first: *"See now that I, even I, am he. There is no god with me."*

Jesus said it last: *"Before Abraham came into existence, I AM."*

They are not two voices. They are one. And He is still saying it, to you, on this page:

I am He. There is no other. Look to Me, and be saved, all the ends of the earth.

The only question left is the one you have to answer yourself.

Who is the "He"?

And what will you do, now that you know?

Appendix — The "I Am He" Formula Across the Scriptures

A reference table of the principal occurrences, with the Hebrew (or Greek, for New Testament texts), transliteration, and the World English Bible rendering. Use it to check every claim in this book against the text itself.

The Hebrew formula — אני הוא ('*ānî hû*', "I am he"); emphatic form אנכי הוא ('*ānōkî 'ānōkî hû*', "I, I am he"). **Septuagint Greek**: ἐγώ εἰμι (*egō eimi*). **Vulgate Latin**: *ego sum* / *ego ipse*.

Reference	Speaker	Formula	WEB rendering (excerpt)
Deuteronomy 32:39	Yahweh	' <i>ānî 'ānî hû</i> '	"See now that I, even I, am he. There is no god with me."
Isaiah 41:4	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"I, Yahweh, the first, and with the last, I am he."
Isaiah 43:10	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"that you may know and believe me, and understand that I am he."
Isaiah 43:11	Yahweh	—	"Besides me there is no savior."
Isaiah 43:13	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"Yes, since the day was, I am he."
Isaiah 43:25	Yahweh	' <i>ānōkî 'ānōkî hû</i> '	"I, even I, am he who blots out your transgressions."
Isaiah 44:6	Yahweh	—	"I am the first, and I am the last; and besides me there is no God."
Isaiah 46:4	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"Even to old age I am he... I will carry you."
Isaiah 48:12	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"I am he. I am the first. I am also the last."
Isaiah 52:6	Yahweh	' <i>ānî hû</i> '	"they shall know in that day that I am he who speaks."

Reference	Speaker	Formula	WEB rendering (excerpt)
Isaiah 45:22–23	Yahweh	—	"I am God, and there is no other... to me every knee will bow."
Mark 6:50	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"Cheer up! It is I! Don't be afraid."
Mark 14:62	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"I am. You will see the Son of Man... coming with the clouds."
John 4:26	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"I am he, the one who speaks to you." (to the Samaritan woman)
John 6:20	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"It is I. Don't be afraid."
John 8:24	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"unless you believe that I am he, you will die in your sins."
John 8:28	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"then you will know that I am he."
John 8:58	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"before Abraham came into existence, I AM."
John 13:19	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"you may believe that I am he."
John 18:5–6	Jesus	<i>egō eimi</i>	"I am he." (and they fell to the ground)
Revelation 1:17–18	Jesus	—	"I am the first and the last, and the Living one. I was dead, and... alive forever."
Revelation 22:13	Jesus	—	"I am the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last."

About this book

I AM HE is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry** so that the knowledge of the glory of the Lord might fill the earth as the waters cover the sea. It may be read, shared, quoted, and

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"Christ in you, the hope of glory." — Colossians 1:27 (WEB)